

THE MUGHALS REVISITED

These narratives by priests, merchants and adventurers greatly influenced western ideas about India



BEYOND THE THREE SEAS: TRAVELLERS' TALES OF MUGHAL INDIA
 Edited by MICHAEL H. FISHER
 Random House
 Price: Rs 350, Pages: 219

■ By Gillian Wright

Generally I thoroughly approve of recycling—be it paper, glass, plastic or aluminum. But I am not always sure about literary recycling. A number of Europeans wrote accounts of their travels in India during the time of the Great Mughals. These accounts, happily for publishers, are long out of copyright. The principal ones—Tavernier, Bernier, Manucci and Monserrate—are still in print and readily available in Delhi bookshops. So for me it is a bit of a mystery why Random House India would publish Michael H. Fisher's abridged versions of these accounts together with those of six other travellers. I suppose anthologies are always considered a good bet.

The writers in this one—priests, merchants and adventurers from Italy, Russia, Spain, France and England—did have lively and varied experiences of different regions of India between the period before Babur took over and the reign of Shah Jahan. Fisher allows them to speak for themselves—in fact rather too much for themselves. Apart from an extended introduction, he does not attempt to contextualise their stories. Bearing in mind that these writers were unfamiliar with India and often made mistakes, and the gulf of time between them and today's reader, explanatory notes would have been worthwhile.

In his introduction Fisher makes a valid point that these narratives were written with an eye on being published in Europe and furthering the interests of the writers. They were important because they greatly influenced western ideas of what India was like. Fisher also expresses some wonder at the fact that Indian travellers abroad during this period did not publish accounts of their travels. He forgets the Mughals never used a printing press. The great Mughals had libraries but they were hand-written. Who knows what narrative accounts have been lost to us because they were mere manuscripts.

Fisher's chosen European trav-

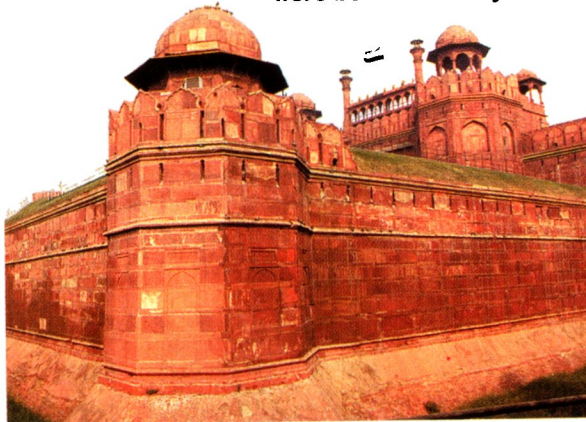
on in a bookkhana, which Fisher wrongly glosses as a place for *bhoots* or demons. *Butkhana* (room for images) is an Urdu word for a temple.

Then there is the merchant Cesare Federici who visits Vijaynagar and is one of the first Europeans to describe a sati in detail. Friar Sebastian Manrique (1585-1669) took a short cut from South-east Asia to Rome by travelling across Bengal and up the Ganga. At a village halt, one of his companions strangled two tame peacocks and to conceal the crime they ate them for dinner. They all considered their Hindu hosts' respect for life ridiculous, but their hosts made sure that the whole lot of them were thrown in jail and only bribery and corruption saved the peacock-killer's hand from being chopped off.

The Englishman, William Hawkins, in contrast, spoke Turkish and was at home in the Mughal court. He accepted emperor Jahangir's offer of his Armenian ward's hand in marriage, and warned the emperor against the machinations of the Catholics. A generation earlier, the Jesuit Father Antonio Monserrate had waited in vain for Akbar to convert to Christianity ever since he dressed in Portuguese clothes one day.

These travellers were products of their times, and in those days there was no such concept among European Christians as "multi-faith". But they were not simply bigots. Fisher argues that the western response to India, even then, was nuanced, not monolithic. This anthology supports his view that there were different kinds of men with different levels of understanding then, just as there are today. ■

AWESTRUCK: The travellers were bowled over by India



ellers were certainly bowled over by Incredible India, while, looking at most of them, few if any Indians would have realised how important Europe was going to become to India. Take for example the 16th-Century Russian horse trader Afanasy Nikitin, who believed in a gookook bird that killed men by perching on their houses. His account is brief but stunning. "The land is overstocked with people," he sagely remarks before embarking on a description of the goings

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